Capitol Hill Crawler: Systemic Architecture & Narrative Guide (V3)

Document Purpose: This comprehensive Game Design Document (GDD) and Story Bible serves as a production-ready master blueprint for game architects, systems engineers, and narrative designers. It formalizes all game mechanics, state loops, character nodes, database tables, and economy balances for the Tier 1 Campaign on Chromebook platforms.

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1. Introduction & Core Narrative Purpose

On its surface, *Capitol Hill Crawler* looks and plays like a cozy, cutesy 16-bit handheld RPG. Beneath the pixelated, charming aesthetics lies a powerful, dual-purpose educational engine designed to teach players:

1. The exact 100-question database of the **U.S. Citizenship Naturalization Test**.
2. The mechanical reality of **how a bill structurally becomes a law** amidst partisan gridlock, committees, filibusters, and veto pens.

1.1 The Cutesy Narrative Framework

To turn dry civic procedures into an engaging RPG world, the narrative is framed as a whimsical adventure. The player takes on the role of a bright-eyed, freshly elected "Freshman Representative" stepping off the train into a colorful, sprawling Capitol City. Instead of terrifying monsters or dark dragons, the dungeon "bosses" and "creatures" are stubborn, sleepy, or overly hyperactive politicians, eccentric archivists, and dramatic caucuses blocking the hallways. Passing a piece of legislation isn't handled via dull legislative paperwork; it is a grand quest! Your bill is an actual physical, glowing scroll that you carry on your back. To protect your bill, you must navigate a maze of office desks, venture through underground subway systems, and venture into the scary "Committee Rooms" to gather signatures and defend your policy ideas in high-energy civic debates.

1.2 The Gameplay Objectives (In Simple Terms)

To fully clear a campaign run and win the game, the player must accomplish a clear checklist of milestones:

- **What You Must Do:** Take your chosen Bill from a raw draft on the House Floor, push it past a massive gridlock of 218 House votes, survive a frantic 60-vote Senate Filibuster gauntlet, and get it signed inside the Oval Office.
- **How You Must Do It:** Explore map layouts to find and talk to different political cliques. Solve trivia encounters by typing or choosing the correct answers to real U.S. Citizenship Test questions. Collect Influence Points to buy power-up items, and embark on side-quests to gather secret clues for your personal Notebook to ace the final exams.

2. The Polarization Scale Engine & Technical Math

The game tracking system treats political ideology as a bounded, continuous numerical array [0, 100]. This scale directly controls user UI configurations, pathing difficulties, and enemy aggression states.

- **Left-Leaning / Progressive Factions:** Bounded between $0 \le x \le 49$.
- **Right-Leaning / Conservative Factions:** Bounded between $51 \le x \le 100$.
- **Absolute Bipartisanship Equilibrium:** Set exactly at $x = 50$.

When a player selects their political party affiliation, the database configurations persistently establish them within a parliamentary minority chamber. Progression relies heavily on calculated interactions between the player's bill anchor value and target representative nodes.

2.1 Mathematical Difficulty Delta

Let B_v represent the active Bill Value (fixed at 50 for Tier 1) and N_r represent the polarization rating of the Target Representative Node. The absolute difficulty modifier D is calculated as:

$D = |B_v - N_r|$

The value of D alters the interface constraints programmatically:

Difficulty Delta (D)	Party Context	UI Interface Mode	Mechanic Constraints
$0 \le D \le 5$	Intra-Party (Ally)	3-Option Multiple Choice Grid	Standard timing constraints; straightforward questions.
$D \ge 40$	Intra-Party (Extremist)	12-Option High-Confusion Grid	Answers populate with highly similar semantic phrasing to penalize guessing.
$5 \le D \le 15$	Cross-Aisle (Opposition)	Open-Ended Keyboard Text Input	Dialogue provides localized text hints highlighted in the UI.
$D \ge 40$	Cross-Aisle (Extremist)	Mumbled Open-Ended Text Input	Text box rendering is dynamically scrambled, omitting crucial keywords.

3. Level 1: The House Wing Floor Map Architecture

The layout uses a classical rigid, cell-based bounding box design mapping directly to 16x16 pixel movement grids. Decorative constituent sprites are hardcoded to their spatial coordinates to act as organic maze barriers, forcing the player to map paths directly toward interactable Faction Leaders.

3.1 Text-Based Tile Map Visualization

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| [HOUSE COMMITTEE ROOMS]        [WEST CLOAKROOM]           [EAST CLOAKROOM]
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| +---------+  +---------+       +--------------+            +--------------+     |
| |  [C1]   |  |  [C2]   |       |   (R) (R)    |            |   (R) (R)    |     |
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|                        |   SPEAKER PODIUM|                          |
|                        |    [STAGE BOSS] |                         |
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|      +----------------------------------------------------------+         |
|      |                 THE MAIN HOUSE FLOOR CHAMBER              |         |
|      |                                            |         |
|      |   [LOYALIST WEST CAUCUS]             [LOYALIST EAST CAUCUS]   |         |
|      |    (M) (M) (M)                     (M) (M) (M)            |         |
|      |    (M) [LEADER 1] (M)                 (M) [LEADER 2] (M)       |         |
|      |                                            |         |
|      |              [BIPARTISAN SOLVERS COALITION]                |         |
|      |               (B) (B) (B) (B) (B) (B) (B)                  |         |
|      |               (B) (B)     [LEADER 3]  (B) (B)                  |         |
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| | EXTRMST |          |     THE CAPITOL ROTUNDA (HUB)     |                       |
| | AMBUSH  |=========>|                                |==========> TO SENATE    |
| | ZONE    |          |   [INFLUENCE STORE]  [SAVE POINT]|           WING DNGN    |
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| +---------+         |     [SHOP NPC]         [P1]     |                    |
|                  +----------------------------------+                    |
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3.2 Map Coordinate & Legend Assignments

- **[P1]:** Player Spawn point / Central Hub Orientation Anchor.
- **[LEADER X]:** Faction/Coalition Head Intermediation Nodes. Interacting with them activates macro-vote transactions.
- **(M) / (B) / (R):** Static, non-moveable decorative placeholder sprites. They serve as physical collision blockades.
- **[X] / #:** Asset Hitbox Gates / Open Navigation Scene Thresholds.
- **[C1] / [C2]:** Committee Room Map Instance sub-vectors.
- **====:** Collidable structural wall geometries. Cross-navigation is hard-blocked.

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4. House Character Manifest & Behavioral Dialogue Trees

Below are production strings and metadata variables for the core narrative interaction nodes within Level 1.

4.1 NPC-01: Rep. Sarah Sterling (The Bipartisan Catalyst)

- **Location:** House Chamber Center Circle
- **Polarization Coordinate:** 51 (Moderate Opposition)
- **Controlled Block Value:** 40 Votes (Bipartisan Solvers Coalition)
- **UI Mode:** Open-ended input text box with active visual context hints.

[GREETING DIALOGUE]: "Look, kid, my faction doesn't care about partisan bloodsports. We want to see bridges repaired and national parks protected. If you can prove you possess even a baseline knowledge of why this government exists, my whole caucus will sign onto your bill. Let's start with a foundational question: Who is in charge of the executive branch?"
[SUCCESS DIALOGUE]: "Clean answer. Solid execution. That's what I like to see. You've officially secured all 40 of my members on your legislative tracking board. Go give 'em hell on the house floor."

4.2 NPC-02: Rep. Marcus Vance (The Progressive Purist)

- **Location:** House Chamber Far-West Wing Corner
- **Polarization Coordinate:** 5 (Intra-Party Extremist Gatekeeper)
- **Controlled Block Value:** 15 Votes (Progressive Coalition)
- **UI Mode:** 12-Option Matrix Selection Grid.

[AMBUSH DIALOGUE]: "Stop right there, freshman. I see you running around collecting moderate opposition votes, cutting out our party's progressive environmental protections just to appease corporate centrists. This bill is watered down! If you want our 15 votes to push you over the finish line, you better prove your absolute loyalty to foundational jurisprudence. Answer me this, or your precious little compromise goes straight back to Committee!"

5. Master Legislative Procedural Logic Loops

5.1 The Automated 175-Vote Trigger (The Extremist Ambush)

The global game engine constantly listens to the integer variable Vote_Counter. The moment the criteria Vote_Counter ≥ 175 is met, standard movement arrays are locked out, and an Extremist Boss Node sprite is hardcoded to slide directly into the player's pathway coordinates. This battle functions as a systemic branching gate based on text input evaluation:

- **Branch A (Correct Text Matrix Input):** Sets global variable Committee_Status = Friendly_Markup. The Extremist node registers as a temporary modifier asset, bypassing combat hurdles in the Committee Room mini-dungeon and unlocking their entire coalition block upon map exit.
- **Branch B (Incorrect / Timeout Entry Matrix):** Sets global variable Committee_Status = Hostile_Markup. The Committee Room instantiates as an aggressive gauntlet. The player must run around negotiating with individual backbenchers while the Extremist transforms into the final chamber floor boss block.

5.2 Level 2: The Senate Floor and the Filibuster Gate

The Senate map compresses the layout from dozens of small factions into 10 major Faction Nodes, each commanding exactly 10 votes. To advance, the player must achieve Cloture by hitting Senate_Vote_Counter ≥ 60.

- **The 50-Vote Barrier:** The moment the player reaches exactly 50 Senate votes, the Opposition Leadership seizes the central Rostrum, instantiating the **Filibuster Gauntlet**.
- **The Cloture Gauntlet Mechanic:** The player is thrust into a back-to-back string of 5 Multiple-Choice Questions (4 options each). No pauses are permitted between arrays. Winning this gauntlet automatically breaks the filibuster and exits the map to the Executive level.
- **The Overtime Fail Loop:** If the player fails the gauntlet, the Senate chamber sets an environmental Gridlock flag. The exit remain locked, and the player must explore hidden Cloakroom and Subway grid maps to manually hunt down 10 individual *Rogue Senator Nodes*, solving open-ended challenges with zero hints to compile the missing 10 votes.

6. Comprehensive Citizenship Exam Database

6.1 Multiple Choice Schema (Intra-Party & Gauntlet Loops)

Question ID: MC_01 (Moderate Balance Node)
Question Text: What is the supreme law of the land?
Render UI Layout: 3-Option Configuration Grid

A: The Declaration of Independence
B: The Constitution **[CORRECT]**
C: The Articles of Confederation
Question ID: MC_02 (Extremist Balance Node - High Confusion Array)
Question Text: The Federalist Papers supported the passage of the U.S. Constitution. Name one of the writers.
Render UI Layout: 12-Option Exhaustive Matrix Grid
A: Thomas Jefferson | *B:* John Adams | *C:* Alexander Hamilton **[CORRECT]** | *D:* Benjamin Franklin | *E:* George Mason | *F:* Patrick Henry | *G:* Samuel Adams | *H:* Thomas Paine | *I:* John Hancock | *J:* Paul Revere | *K:* Aaron Burr | *L:* James Monroe

6.2 Open-Ended Schema (Opposition Nodes)

Question ID: OE_01 (Moderate Opposition)
Question Text: Who is in charge of the executive branch?
Dialogue Helper Hint: "Think about the individual office that occupies the White House and sits directly in the Oval Office..."
Programmatic Accept Array: ["president", "the president", "president of the united states", "potus"]
Question ID: OE_02 (Extremist Opposition - Mumbled UI Render)
Screen Text Obfuscation String: "You think you can pass this... *grunt*... tell me this right now... ...under underlying cause... **Civil War**... executive order... **freed the slaves**... what *mumble* called?!"
Target Question Mapping: What was the executive order that freed the slaves during the Civil War?
Programmatic Accept Array: ["emancipation proclamation", "emancipation", "the emancipation proclamation", "emancipasion proclamation"]

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7. In-Game Economy, Side Quests, & Notebook Data Structures

6.1 The Rotunda Store Asset Inventory

Correct responses increment the player currency variable Influence_Points (INF) by 50 units. Players trade INF points at the safe-zone shop vendor located in the Central Rotunda Hub map.

Item System ID	INF Point Cost	Programmatic State Modification Effect
ITEM_TALKING_POINTS	50 INF	Strips 3 incorrect choice strings away from any around active Multiple-Choice grid interface.
ITEM_HEARING_AID	75 INF	Replaces two active obfuscated "..." markup strings with their true plaintext keywords.
ITEM_CAFETERIA_COFFEE	40 INF	Completely stops the

Item System ID	INF Point Cost	Programmatic State Modification Effect
		countdown execution thread of the "Point of Order" confidence timer in the Senate.
ITEM_SUPER_PAC_INJECT	500 INF	Sets flag to automatically bypass 5 required Rogue Senator nodes during the Senate Overtime loop.

6.2 Side Quest Data Structures

Quest ID: QUEST_ARCHIVIST_LEDGER
Trigger Node: Sen. Eleanor Vance (Coordinate 55 - Senate East Corridor)
Condition String: Active Hold state flag placed on bill. Player must fetch "Economic Impact Briefing" from the basement archive maze asset.
Notebook Output Variable: Appends a readable data array object to the player's Notebook Interface (Tab overlay):
[NOTEBOOK LOGGED]: The House of Representatives has exactly 435 voting members.

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8. Level 3: The Oval Office Final Boss and Leaderboard Scoring

Upon passing both congressional chambers, a binary programmatic evaluation executes a 50/50 randomized coin-flip routine to determine Executive Alignment.

7.1 Ally President Encounter Loop

Instantiates a 10-Question Multiple Choice matrix (4 choices each). The moment a counter matches Correct_Answers = 6, the scene transitions immediately to a success state, blocking further questions. Unanswered questions are computed directly into the high score variable:
Final_Score = Base_Clear_Points + (Unanswered_Questions * 150)

7.2 Opposition President Showdown Loop

Instantiates a 10-Question Open-Ended text entry field under a hardcoded 30-second ticking clock per question block. To facilitate frantic typing on Chromebook hardware, the compiler string matching algorithm changes from strict evaluation to a Levenshtein edit distance check of ≤ 2. Accumulating 6 successful inputs overrides the Veto flag and marks the campaign tier as fully cleared.